



The US and China are seen as the two superpowers in the global AI race. With what you have achieved—and with others now building and launching in this space—how far is India from emerging as the third pillar in the global AI order?

Kumar: We have a long way to go, primarily because the goal for us, divorced from other people and what they are doing, is that the technology should be accessible to all. That is where India has succeeded, whether it's Aadhaar or UPI. AI must follow that template. In fact, we're focused quite a bit on that. But creating use cases and getting them in the hands of people across the length and breadth of the country is a problem worth solving. Of course, people like us will continue building the next model, keep competing globally. But as a nation, our goal should be to get it in the hands of as many people as possible.



What are your long-term ambitions? What do you ultimately aspire to achieve with this model?

Kumar: These models



Vivek Raghavan, co-founder, Sarvam AI

continue to improve rapidly. That's the great thing about this technology. The levers of improvement are still very strong.

So, we will continue to improve the models. Over the next several months, our primary focus will be on reach: how do we ensure this technology is accessible to more people? How do we build the right infrastructure in the country to maximise availability and access?

In fact, for access, we're also looking at things like devices. We're building smart glasses (Sarovam Kaze). We're genuinely excited by what people will do when they touch this technology. Its capabilities are unprecedented. With devices like smart glasses, our aim is to make intelligence accessible anytime, anywhere.



There has been considerable commen-

tary about the perceived gap between this model and GPT-5. Is it relevant to the broader debate?

Raghavan: When we started Aadhaar, all the standards for identity were proprietary, and foreign companies owned them. And we built something that was indigenous and on open standards, and it led to the creation of the India Stack. We gained a long arc from that. We should not evaluate this by looking at where a model stands today or who has the largest model or the fastest chip? That is a short-term perspective. Technology will keep evolving; something new will emerge tomorrow.

We need to focus on the long arc. Sovereignty matters over the long term, and that is precisely why this effort is necessary. Without it, we risk becoming a digital colony. I can't say it more starkly than that.



Where do you believe AI will see the greatest success in India in terms of applications?

Kumar: I think enterprises are yet to deeply adopt this technology. There are some successes. This year will become an inflection point with more reliable ways of looking at deployments. For example, in voice AI, where bots call you and do some interesting things, we are now able to do millions of minutes of voice calling per day on our platform. I see that growing in double-digit percentages a month. On the consumer side, there are, of course, chat apps.

I'm very excited about device form factors as it has an appeal where you want to buy it, experience it, or touch it. And then there are developers who can build interesting things with it. **BT**

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